

A Traveler's Guide to Japan

Japan is a country where ancient traditions and futuristic cities exist side by side. From the neon streets of Tokyo to the quiet temples of Kyoto, it offers something for almost every kind of traveler. This guide covers the essentials: when to go, how to get around, what to eat, and how to be respectful of local customs.

Best Time to Visit

Spring, from late March to early April, is famous for cherry blossoms and is the most popular season, though also the most crowded and expensive. Autumn, from October to November, offers similarly beautiful scenery with red and orange foliage and fewer crowds. Summer is hot and humid with occasional typhoons, while winter is cold but excellent for visiting hot springs and ski resorts in the north.

Getting Around the Country

The Japan Rail Pass is one of the best value options for visitors planning to travel between multiple cities, since it allows unlimited rides on most JR trains including many shinkansen bullet train lines. Within cities, subway and bus networks are extremely reliable and almost always run on time. IC cards such as Suica or Pasmo can be used for trains, buses, and even vending machines, making them convenient for short trips.

Food and Dining Etiquette

Japanese cuisine goes far beyond sushi. Ramen, tempura, okonomiyaki, and kaiseki multi-course meals are all worth trying depending on the region. When eating at a restaurant, it is considered polite to say itadakimasu before starting a meal and gochisousama after finishing. Tipping is not customary in Japan and can sometimes cause confusion if offered, since good service is expected as a standard rather than something to be rewarded separately.

Accommodation Options

Travelers can choose between international hotel chains, traditional ryokan inns with tatami floors and futon bedding, capsule hotels for budget-conscious solo travelers, and guesthouses for a more local experience. Ryokan stays often include a kaiseki dinner and breakfast, and many come with access to an onsen, a traditional Japanese hot spring bath.

Cultural Etiquette and Customs

Bowing is the standard greeting rather than shaking hands, though a handshake is generally accepted with foreign visitors. Shoes should be removed before entering homes, many traditional restaurants, and temples. Speaking loudly on public transportation, especially on the phone, is considered inconsiderate. When visiting shrines and temples, visitors are expected to be quiet and respectful, and photography is sometimes restricted in certain sacred areas.

Budget Tips for Travelers

Convenience stores, known locally as konbini, offer surprisingly good and affordable meals at any hour. Many temples and public parks are free to enter, and some of the best experiences in Japan, such as walking through a traditional neighborhood or watching a local festival, cost nothing at all. Traveling slightly outside peak cherry blossom season can significantly reduce both flight and hotel prices.